

FER at SemEval-2026 Task 6: Analysis of Different Approaches to Unmasking Political Question Evasions



UNIVERSITY OF ZAGREB

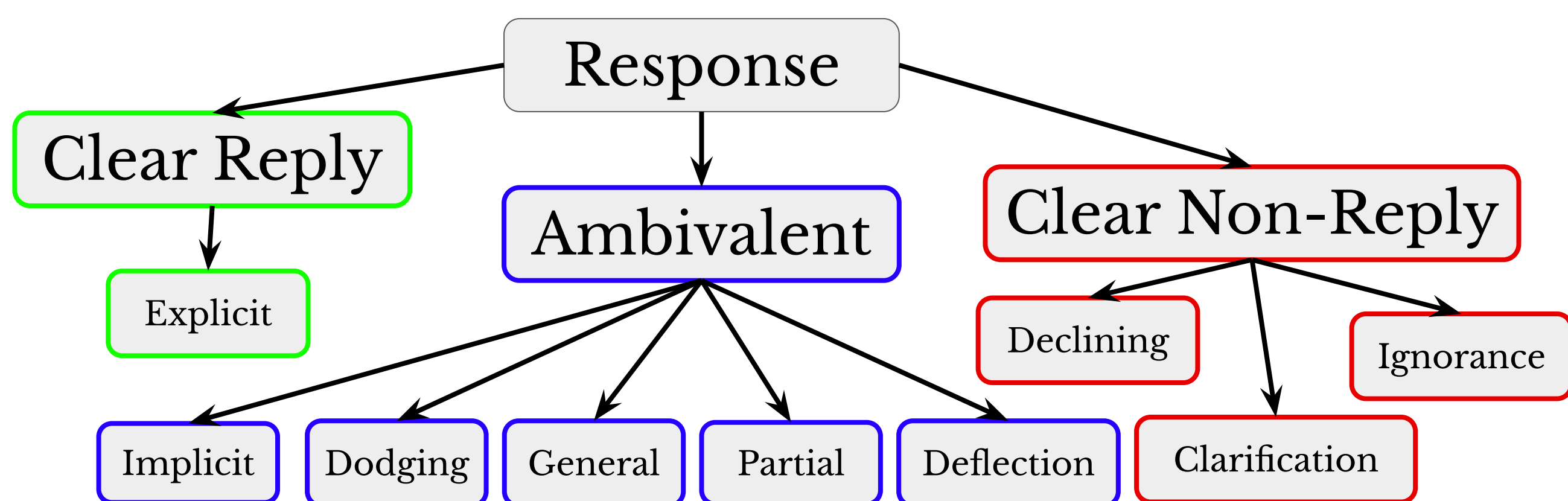
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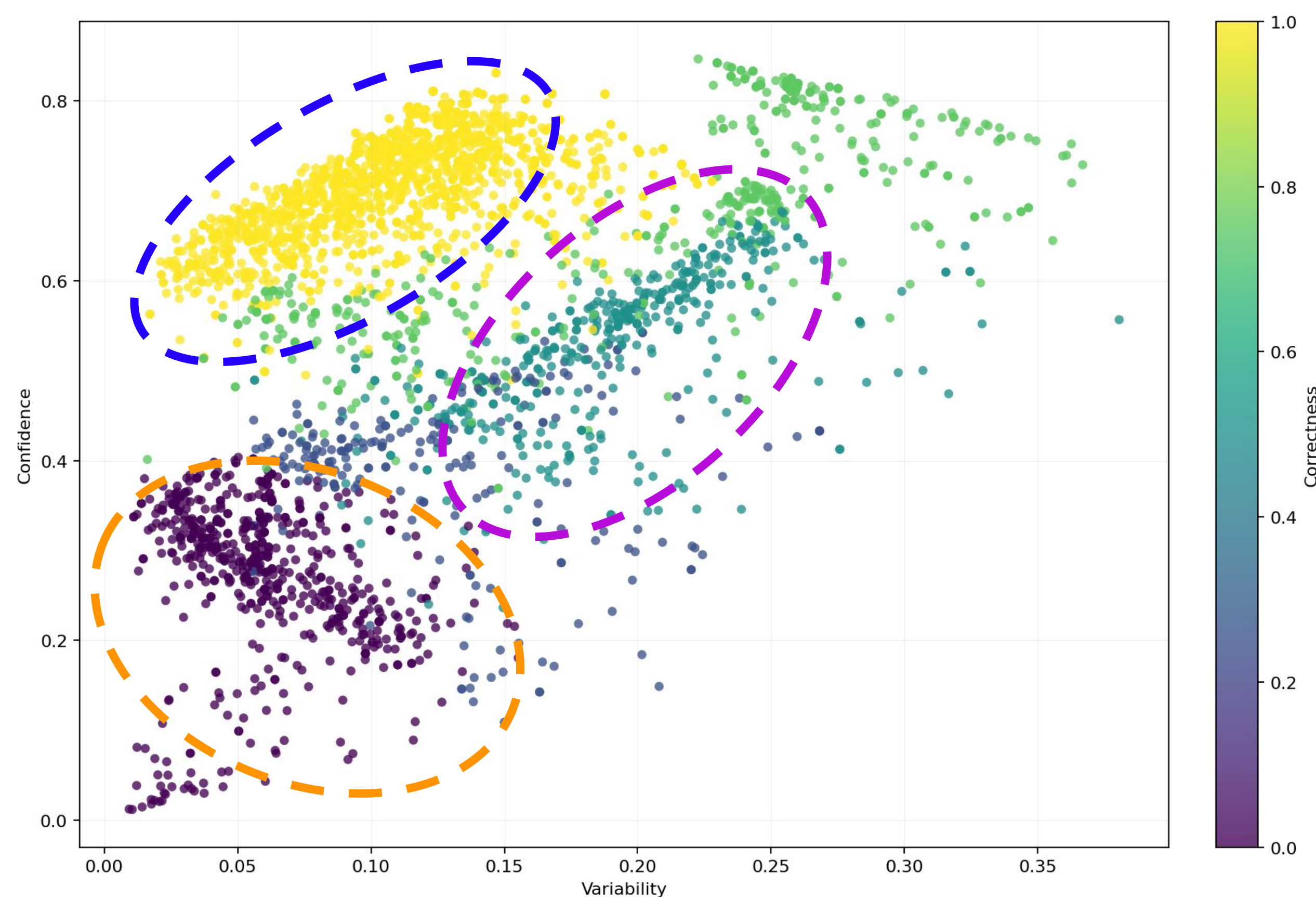
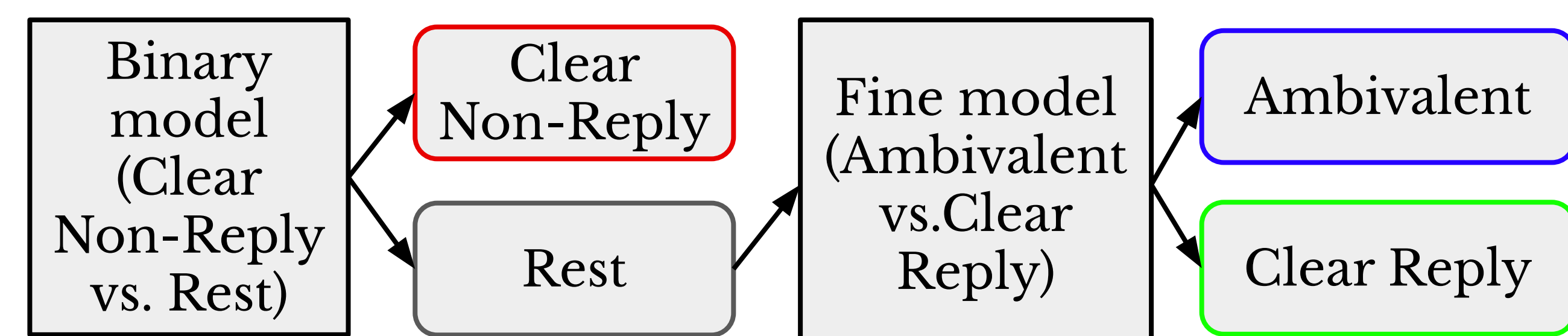
Task

Politicians often give evasive and ambiguous answers to sensitive questions during interviews. This task proposes a hierarchical classification which consists of two layers: (i) clarity-level classification (*Clear Reply*, *Ambivalent* and *Clear Non-Reply*) and (ii) evasion-level classification (nine classes). **Data:** 3,448 QA pairs, 4 U.S. presidents, strong class imbalance; official match-any metric over 3 annotators.



Hierarchical approach

First, we train a “binary” model which separates one clarity class from another. Then a second one which classifies the other two classes. We use *BERT* & *RoBERTa-base*. The figure below is a **dataset cartography map** of training samples which shows easy, ambiguous and difficult examples for a model (*Clear Non-Reply vs. Rest*, *RoBERTa-base*) to learn.

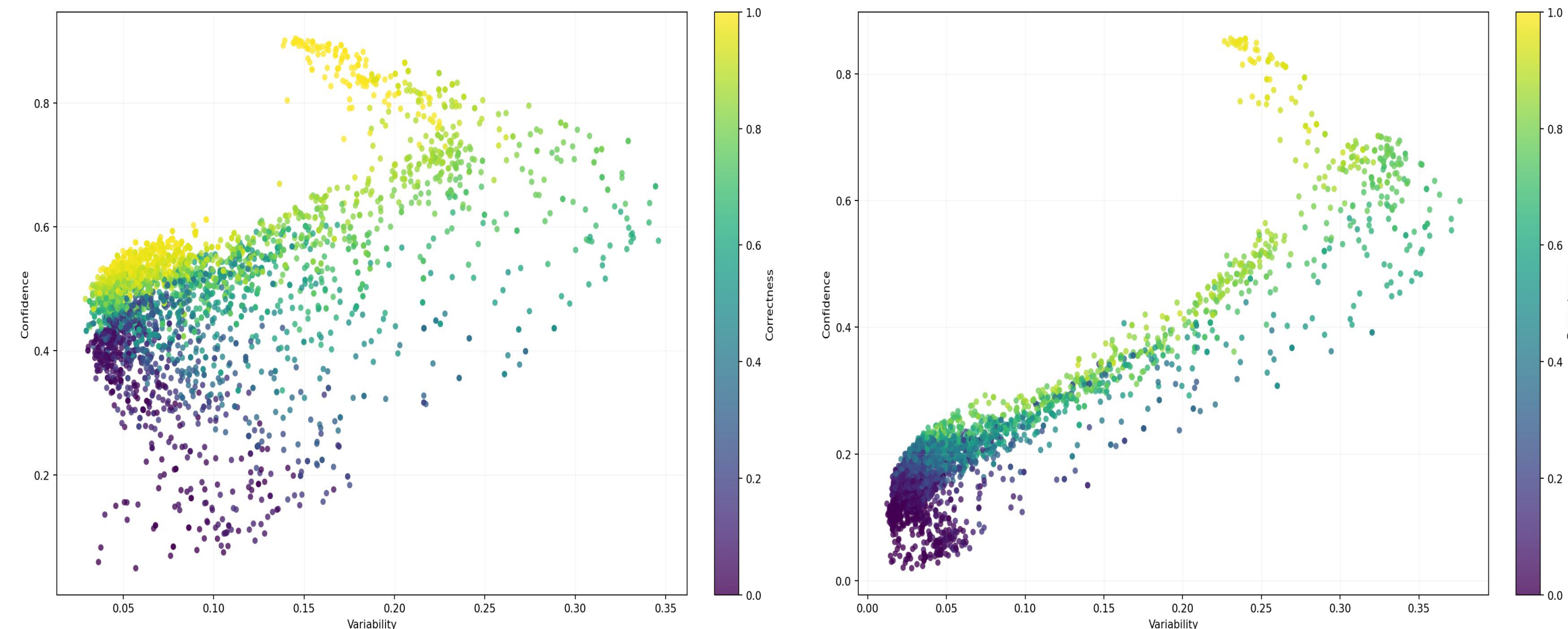


- Easy-to-learn
- Ambiguous
- Hard-to-learn

Isolating *Clear Non-Reply* first, a linguistically distinct and on average shorter class, gives the best clarity score.

Multitask approach

A single shared encoder learns both clarity and evasion tasks simultaneously by using separate prediction heads so the tasks can benefit from shared language representations.



Clarity-level cartography map and evasion-level map.

Independent: A shared encoder predicts clarity and evasion with separate heads, which produce up to 10% invalid label combinations. To fix invalid pairs, **joint** predicts valid clarity-evasion pairs directly as a single class, while **Constrained** keeps separate predictions but masks out invalid combinations during inference.

Results

Approach (Task)	Model	F1 Score
Hierarchical, Clear Non-Reply vs. Rest (<i>Clarity</i>)	RoBERTa-base	0.603
Constrained Multitask (<i>Evasion</i>)	BERT-base	0.438

Region	Example
Easy-to-learn	Q: Would you encourage Congress to pay for school testing? A: I would if they want.
Ambiguous	Q: What exactly is un-American about those programs? A: We are going to do a report; those people are gone.
Hard-to-learn	Q: Can the President go around Congress? A: You ever hear the word obstruction?

Future work

- Larger models/LLMs (Llama, Qwen)
- Multilingual QA datasets
- More advanced ensemble architectures
- Graph-based decoding

